Every Brilliant Thing

By Duncan Macmillan and Jonny Donahoe

NARRATOR: **(Pg 13)** The list began after her first attempt. A list of everything brilliant about the world. Everything worth living for.

1. **Ice cream.**
2. **Water fights.**
3. **Staying up past your bedtime and being allowed to watch TV.**
4. **The color yellow.**
5. **Things with stripes.**
6. **Rollercoasters.**
7. **People falling over.**

All things that, at seven, I thought were really good but not necessarily things Mum would agree with. I started the list on the 9th of November…

INTRODUCTION

Every Brilliant Thing by Duncan MacMillan and Jonny Donahoe

NARRATOR: **(Pg 14)** Up until that day, my only experience of death was that of my dog, Sherlock Bones. He was a central part of my existence . . . [but] he was really sick and so the vet came around to put him down. *(Enters the memory . . . He/she kneels and cradles Sherlock Bones in his arms)* **(Pg 16-17)** I held Sherlock Bones, who I'd known my entire life. I held him as he died. *(Strokes the dog gently)* And I thought about the walk we'd had that morning. And about the smell of him in my room. His toys in the garden. His bed under the stairs. All the things that could now be thrown away. *(Stares at the dog for a long moment)* And he became lighter. Or heavier, I'm not sure. But different. *(Exits the memory, as he/she stands)*And that was my experience of death. A loved one, becoming an object . . and being taken away forever.

(Pg 17-21) *(He/she sits or crouches to wait)* [So] It's the 9th of November. All the other kids had gone home long ago. Eventually, my Dad pulls up. *(He/she stands and peers through*

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

the car window) Dad looked at me . . . When something bad happens, your body feels it before your brain can know what's happening. It's a survival mechanism. It feels like a trapdoor opening beneath you. Fight or flight or stand as still as you can. I stood very still, looking at my Dad . . . Eventually, I got into the car.

DAD: Put on your seatbelt. Cars can be dangerous because other drivers don't always pay attention.

NARRATOR: Why?

DAD: Well, because there's lots to think about when you're a grown up. There are bills to pay and work to do and relationships to sustain and there's never enough time to do it all.

NARRATOR: Why?

DAD: Because there are only twenty-four hours in a day

NARRATOR: Why?

DAD: Because . . . . I don't know everything . . . If you were able to know everything then life would be unlivable.

NARRATOR: Why?

DAD: Because then there would be no mystery, no curiosity, no creativity, no conversation, no discovery. Nothing would be new ad we'd have no need to use our imaginations. Our imaginations are what make life bearable . . . In order to live in the present we have to be able to imagine a future that will be better than the past. Put your seatbelt on. We're going to the hospital.

NARRATOR: Why?

DAD: Because that's where your mother is. She hurt herself. . . she can't see anything worth living for.

NARRATOR: At least, that's how I like to remember it. But we actually just sat in silence The only thing he said to me was:

DAD: Your Mother's done something stupid.

NARRATOR: I didn't know what that meant. . . At the hospital, Mum saw me and said 'not him.' So I sat in the corridor *(He/she sits looks around for a moment, then takes a notebook from*

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

his backpack) I don't know exactly when I had the idea for the list, but it was here that I started to write it down. **(Pg 23)**

23. Danger Mouse
24. Spaghetti
25. Wearing a cape

(Pg 26-31) Mum did eventually come home from the hospital, and by that time the list was eights pages long and h ad three hundred and fourteen things on it. I left it on her pillow with the title: **EVERY BRILLIANT THING.** She never mentioned it to me, but I knew she'd read it because she'd corrected my spelling.

I don't want to make it sound like my Mother was a monster or that my childhood was miserable because it wasn't. *(In a cheerful voice)* We had a piano in our kitchen. We'd gather around it and sing soul songs. There's a Ray Charles song, "Drown in My own Tears" that she sang a lot. *(Sing a few lines from the song*)*

313: Having a piano in the kitchen

I forgot about the list until her second attempt, just over ten years later. Dad showed up halfway through Chemistry. The same trapdoor feeling. Fight or flight. The same wordless drive to the hospital. As a teenager I dealt with it less well. The night she came home and said that if it wasn't for the ham and pineapple pizza lining her stomach from the night before she'd be dead. And I said . . .

You took three weeks' worth of anti-depressants, a packet of Aspirin and half a tub of antihistamines. You're probably healthier than I am. If you're going to kill yourself go jump off a bridge.

Rather than storm off, I sat there and was furious that she was wishing she was dead. *(Long silence)* And then she started to laugh. I started shaking. Have you ever had that? Where you notice that hour hands are shaking and your breaking is deeper and you realize that, ***I'm really upset***. I must be really upset.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

I couldn't sleep that night. I started to clear out my room. Inside a box under my bed, I found the list.

1. Ice cream
2. Water fights

The younger me had dealt with this so much better. The younger me was hopeful. Naïve, of course, but hopeful. I picked up a pen and continued where that little boy had left off.

315. The smell of old books.
316. The even numbered Star Trek films.
317. Making up after an argument.

The next morning I sat at the end of Mum's bed and I read the list to her. She got up and left the room. Over the next few weeks I spent a lot of time talking to her back.

201. Hammocks
761. Deciding you're not too old to climb trees.

I began leaving Post-It notes around the house . . .

575. Piglets
823. Skinny dipping.

It was my aim to reach a thousand. No repetition. Things had to be genuinely wonderful and life-affirming. Not too many material items.

992. Knowing to jangle keys at the wildlife park if you want the otters to come out.
995. Really good oranges.

It's common for the children of suicides to blame themselves. It's natural.

999. Sunlight

However much you know that you're not to blame, you can't help feeling like you failed them. It's not fair to feel this way. But it's natural. The first week I left for university, I posted the list to my Mum. When I returned that Christmas I found it on my desk, neatly folded back in its envelope. I still don't know whether or not she had read it. It certainly hadn't seemed to change her outlook. That Christmas was quiet. Difficult. Dad Drove me back to university.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

(Pg 34) I read up on suicide. [It's] contagious. Every time suicide is front-page news, every time a celebrity or a character on prime-time television takes their own life there is a spike in the number of suicides. It's called the "Werther Effect"

1006: (Pg 41) Surprises
1007: Sometimes there is a perfect song to match how you're feeling

(Sing a few lines from the song "Drown in My own Tears" by Ray Charles)*

(Pg 39) I never told anyone about my Mum. Ever. As a kid there were times when . . . I'd have nothing in my lunchbox or I wouldn't have socks on or something and I . . . I didn't want people to think that because my Mother was . . . I don't know.

(Pg 40-42) I have some advice for anyone who has been contemplating suicide. It's really simple advice. It's this: Don't do it. Things get better. They might not always get brilliant . . . but they get better.

(He/she dances and sings a few lines from Move On Up by Curtis Mayfield)*

1008: Dancing in private
1009: Dancing in public, fearlessly

I wrote late into the night.

1010: Reading
1427: No worrying about how much money you're spending

I wanted to get to 2000 and I kept writing as the sun came up. So much to include that my hand cramped up. I passed

2000: Coffee . . . With . . .
2001: Films that are better than the books they're adapted from.

I wrote new list entries every day. Pages and pages of it.

2390: People who can't sing but either don't know or don't care
9995: Falling in love
9999: Staying up all night talking.

(Pg 45) Studies have shown that children with depressed mothers have a heightened reactivity to stress. It actually changes the chemistry of the brain, the fight or flight impulse. But the real risk as I perceived it . . .

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

253263: (Pg 47) The feeling of calm which follows the realization that, although you may be in a regrettable situation, there's nothing you can do about it.

(Pg 45) The real risk, that I'd felt my whole life, was that I would one day feel as low as my Mum had and take the same action. Because alongside the anger and incomprehension is an absolute crystal clear understanding of why someone would no longer want to continue living

- **(Pg 51) That horrible feeling when something is broken and can't ever be fixed**
- **The trapdoor swinging open**
- **Fight or flight or stay as still as you can.**

I'd been feeling like that for a long time. I found it hard to notice new [and brilliant] things . . . the list ended. It was finished. *(Long pause)*

(Pg 54) I did talk to someone. A group. A support group. *(He/she turns to the group)* Hello, everyone. This is my first session. When I was younger I was much better at being happy. At feeling joy. I um . . . . I made a list. Everything that's brilliant about the world. A present for my Mum. It's kind of a long story . . . *(He/she steps out of the group session)*

(Pg 56) I wasn't around for the last time. Dad wasn't around either. A neighbor complained about the exhaust fumes and eventually the police cut through the garage door. Hosepipe through the driver-side window. *(He/she sings softly)*

- **When the dog bites**
- **When the bee stings**
- **When I'm feeling sad**
- **I simply remember my favorite things . . . And then I don't feel so bad ***

31. (Pg 57) Birdsong
45. Hugging
1092. Conversation.

The list hadn't stopped her. Hadn't saved her. Of course it hadn't.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Duncan Macmillan and Jonny Donahoe
ISBN: 978-0822235644
Publisher: Dramatists Play Service
Date (Month/Year): 2016

AWARD HISTORY

2016 National Qualifier
2017 National Qualifier
2018 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier - MS
2020 National Qualifier
2021 National Qualifier
2022 National Qualifier – MS
2023 National Qualifier
2024 National Qualifier
2024 National Qualifier – MS
2025 National Qualifier
NIETOC
IL State Qualifier
IN State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

*"I'll Drown in My own Tears" by Ray Charles (Music)
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=_ekn9dAYfz0
*"I'll Drown in My own Tears" by Ray Charles (Lyrics)
https://genius.com/Ray-charles-drown-in-my-own-tears-lyrics

* "Move On Up" by Curtis Mayfield (Music)
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=6Z66wVo7uNw
*"Move On Up" by Curtis Mayfield (Lyrics)
https://genius.com/Curtis-mayfield-move-on-up-lyrics

*"My Favorite Things by Julie Andrews (Music)
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=33o32C0ogVM
*"My Favorite Things by Julie Andrews (Lyrics)
https://genius.com/Julie-andrews-my-favorite-things-lyrics

NOTE: Song lyrics may require source information for regional, state or national tournaments. Source information provided below:

Title: I'll Drown in My own Tears
Can be ordered from: https://www.musicnotes.com/sheetmusic/mtd.asp?ppn=MN0068798
Author: Henry Glover; performed by Ray Charles
Product #: MN0068798
Publisher: BMG Rights Management
Date (Month/Year): 1952

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

Title: Move on Up
Can be ordered from: https://www.musicnotes.com/sheetmusic/mtd.asp?ppn=MN0116397
Author: Curtis Mayfield
Product #: MN0116397
Publisher: Alfred Publishing Co, Inc
Date (Month/Year): 1970

Title: My Favorite Things
Can be ordered from: https://www.musicnotes.com/sheetmusic/mtd.asp?ppn=MN0045647
Composer: Richard Rogers; Lyricist Oscar Hammerstein; Performed by Julie Andrews
Product #: MN0045647
Publisher: Hal Leonard Music Publishing
Date (Month/Year): 1959

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY